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Building Foundations: The Role of Communication and Onboarding in Academic Advising Training

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Abstract

This project explores the development of a comprehensive academic advisor onboarding workshop that integrates *Uncertainty Reduction Theory (URT)* and *Organizational Socialization Theory (OST)* to enhance advisor role clarity and institutional integration. Recognizing the complexities new advisors face, the project addresses how structured onboarding strategies can alleviate role ambiguity, reduce anxiety, and foster effective advisor-student interactions. The workshop design aligns with NACADA's definition of academic advising, core competencies, and advising approaches to ensure consistency with professional best practices. By incorporating scenario-based learning (covering common advising cases including incoming freshmen, graduating seniors, change of major situations, and students on academic probation), the program emphasizes practical applications of URT's information-seeking behaviors across OST's socialization phases. This integrated model not only aids new advisors in navigating institutional expectations but also prepares them with proactive strategies for ongoing professional development. The anticipated outcome is a scalable, theory-based onboarding framework that supports advisor retention, improves advising quality, and enhances student success.

Keywords: higher education, academic advising, NACADA core competencies, organizational socialization theory, uncertainty reduction theory, advisor training, onboarding, professional development

Introduction

The strategic work of academic advisors plays a crucial role in impacting retention rates and meeting the missions of academic institutions (Menke, Dusliak, & McGill, 2020). As Menke et al. (2020) describes, leadership often underestimates the complexity and essential nature of academic advising, viewing it as something "anyone can simply step into" (Moosa, 2021). The primary responsibility of an academic advisor is to support and guide students in their educational journeys. Advisors occupy a pivotal role in student sense of belonging, course planning, and early identification of at-risk students. These responsibilities are strongly tied to students' persistence, retention and overall academic success. "Managers who offer a climate that empowers advisors to make important decisions, provides opportunities for them to be challenged with a variety of tasks, and orients accomplishing tasks via teamwork and who clearly communicate roles and responsibilities will see advisors flourish as they support the mission of the institution in which they work." (Donnelly 2009, p.13). A thorough understanding of the academic advisor's role is essential for university administrators and faculty.

This knowledge helps them build credibility and trust and provides effective student support while staying up-to-date with policies. Advisors generally report high job satisfaction, especially when their roles include a range of responsibilities, opportunities for empowerment, and strong teamwork. However, their satisfaction dips when they face unclear role expectations, lack of recognition, or insufficient support for career development. According to Donnally (2009, p.13), "it is recommended that advisors be encouraged to clearly understand their jobs, receive good training, and emphasize the interpersonal nature of the work while de-emphasizing technical aspects of it. Ultimately, a proper foundation enhances the effectiveness of academic advising across the institution which can directly improve undergraduate student satisfaction.

Administrators, faculty, and other university stakeholders must recognize the multifaceted nature of the advisor's role. Grites (2009) and Nadler and Nadler (1999) emphasize that clearly defined expectations and systemic support not only enhance advisors' credibility and institutional trust but also lead to improved student outcomes. By providing advisors with comprehensive training in advising techniques, institutional systems, and communication, universities can boost student engagement, satisfaction, and retention, while simultaneously reinforcing the advisor connection to and commitment within the university community.

Combining a structured onboarding process (drawn from organizational socialization and uncertainty reduction theory) with training grounded in NACADA's conceptual, informational, and relational core competencies (NACADA, 2022) can produce a measurable and sustainable model for advisor training. Including these theoretical frameworks into onboarding enhances role clarity and supports advisor development, offering institutions a replicable approach to building advising capacity. The goal is to enhance advisor preparedness, reduce role ambiguity, and ultimately contribute to a more engaged and effective advising workplace.

Onboarding versus Orientation

A comprehensive onboarding program that addresses communication challenges can help advisors navigate obstacles and promote a more personalized advising experience that supports retention. This project will explore how effective onboarding is a more extended and tailored process than orientation, emphasizing helping advisors learn and utilize role-specific tools and systems through methods aligned with their learning styles. These distinctions between orientation and onboarding are significant for integrating new advisors into workplace systems and enhancing performance outcomes. As key players in student success, academic advisors must navigate complex institutional systems and support diverse student needs. Effective onboarding not only

equips advisors with essential skills and knowledge but also helps create a foundation for organizational commitment and job satisfaction, which are crucial in high-touch roles involving student engagement.

Research indicates that structured onboarding programs, which blend systems training and mentorship, significantly improve advisors' performance and their ability to support student retention efforts (Graybill et al., 2013; Wanberg, 2012). Furthermore, comprehensive onboarding cultivates community and fosters clarity in roles and expectations, leading to greater resilience and satisfaction among advisors (Bauer, 2010; Cable et al., 2013). By analyzing onboarding best practices, this study will illustrate how effective communication within advisor onboarding can serve as a strategic investment in the institutional mission of student success and the well-being of academic advisors.

Communication & Onboarding

Communication during onboarding serves as a vehicle for aligning new advisors with institutional expectations, policies, and the overall goal of supporting student success. This communication can take multiple forms, including face-to-face meetings, email updates, training modules, and centralized resources (i.e., internal portal). When communication is consistent and strategically designed, it not only reduces confusion for advisors, but it establishes transparency and open dialogue during the onboarding process.

According to Cable, Gino, and Staats (2013), onboarding processes that allow new employees to express and apply their strengths enhance engagement and job satisfaction, which can be particularly beneficial in high-interaction roles like advising. The previous research highlights the importance of examining communication strategies in onboarding for advisors.

Academic advisors serve as primary points of support for students and benefit significantly from structured onboarding programs that help them understand institutional systems, advising tools, and cultural expectations. According to Goldman et al. (2017), when individuals are intrinsically motivated, they engage with genuine interest, which enhances their skills and expands their capabilities. Familiarity with institutional systems increases advisors' competence and confidence in executing their tasks. Therefore, effective communication embedded in the onboarding process for academic advisors should be a critical focus for higher education institutions.

To facilitate effective communication during onboarding, it must include opportunities for new advisors to ask questions and seek clarification on institutional policies and advising practices. Regular check-ins with supervisors or mentors (i.e., seasoned advisors) create a feedback loop that allows advisors to voice concerns, clarify responsibilities, and reinforce learning. Other interpersonal communication strategies within advisor onboarding may include weekly progress notes or monthly meetings with other advisors can mitigate feelings of isolation that new advisors often experience. Furthermore, effective onboarding for advisors enhances the overall student experience by ensuring that they can provide consistent support, which can lead to higher student retention rates (Wanberg, 2012). Advisors who receive thorough onboarding are more likely to feel connected to an institution's goals and values, reducing turnover rates and increasing organizational loyalty (Graybill et al., 2013). Efficient system training during onboarding allows employees to access relevant resources seamlessly, leading to greater job efficiency and long-term engagement (Snell, 2006). The development of an onboarding process that utilizes key communication strategies that are highlighted in this project.

Justification of Theories

Effective and efficient onboarding for academic advisors requires a structured approach that helps them understand their role, integrate into the institution, and build confidence in student interactions. Organizational Socialization Theory (OST) and Uncertainty Reduction Theory (URT) provide a solid foundation for designing such onboarding programs. OST explains how new employees learn organizational values, expectations, and job roles through formal socialization practices (Van Maanen & Schein, 1979). In academic advising, OST highlights the need for structured training, mentorship, and clear communication of institutional policies to help advisors adjust to their responsibilities. A well-designed onboarding process ensures advisors understand the goals of advising, how to navigate internal systems, and how to collaborate across departments (Bauer et al., 2007). This structured approach reduces confusion, builds professional identity, and prepares advisors to align with institutional goals. URT focuses on how people reduce uncertainty when interacting with others, especially in first-time conversations (Berger & Calabrese, 1975). For new academic advisors, URT is essential in learning how to communicate effectively with students, especially when students are hesitant or unclear about their needs. Training advisors to use passive strategies (observing student behavior), active strategies (gathering information from colleagues and systems), and interactive strategies (engaging directly with students) helps them manage uncertainty and build trust quickly (Holladay & Coombs, 1994).

By combining OST and URT, academic advisor onboarding focuses on both *organizational fit and interpersonal communication*. OST ensures advisors understand institutional expectations and feel integrated, while URT provides them with the skills to navigate student interactions with certainty. Together, these theories create an onboarding experience that prepares advisors to succeed in their roles and support students effectively from day one.

Literature Review

"Many advisors work in demanding, complex environments where job satisfaction can be threatened" (Donnelly, 2009, p.5). Leach and Wang state that "In the communication discipline specifically, faculty members struggle with advising due to a lack of training and preparation for the task" (p. 328). When an academic advisor's style results in unclear expectations the resulting advising-advisee relationship can be especially problematic (Leach & Wang, 2015). These challenges will be taken into consideration when developing the learning objectives that promote communication skills among advisors. To better prepare advisors, onboarding should focus on specific communication skills. These include building rapport with students to create a sense of belonging, collaborative communication to work toward solution-focused interactions, and adaptive communication strategies to adjust communication style based on cultural differences and varying communication preferences (Woodrow & Guest, 2019).

Skills that build advisor competency for student support will be included. Integrating Uncertainty Reduction Theory (URT) and Organizational Role Theory (ORT) offers a comprehensive approach to academic advisor onboarding. URT underscores the importance of proactive information seeking and interpersonal engagement to reduce anxiety and ambiguity during initial organizational entry (Berger & Calabrese, 1975). ORT offers a structural perspective on how individuals assimilate into their roles through phases of anticipatory socialization, encounter, and change and acquisition (Feldman, 1976; Katz & Kahn, 1978). Together, these theories create a collaborative model that supports new advisors in developing role clarity, organizational commitment, and confidence and seasoned advisors who may appreciate a refresher. Institutions that adopt this integrated onboarding framework can expect improved advisor performance, enhanced student support, and a more cohesive advising culture.

NACADA Core Competencies

The National Academic Advising Association (NACADA) is an international professional organization dedicated to promoting the theory, research, and practice of academic advising in higher education (NACADA, 2024). This organization is known as the global community for academic advising. The NACADA Academic Advising Core Competencies encompass conceptual, informational, and relational components essential for effective advising and structured onboarding. The *conceptual* component requires advisors to understand the historical context and purpose of academic advising, core values such as caring and inclusivity, theoretical foundations, advising models, expected outcomes, and equity practices (NACADA, 2017). In onboarding, this might include structured reading of foundational NACADA documents, facilitated group discussions on advising philosophies, and diversity workshops to build inclusive perspectives. The *informational* component involves familiarity with the institution's background, mission, academic programs, policies, student demographics, legal standards, campus support services, and the technology tools applied in advising (NACADA, 2017). New advisors could engage in system demonstrations, policy briefings, and resource mapping exercises, guided by senior advisors or staff, to ensure they are well-versed in institutional frameworks. The *relational* component emphasizes interpersonal skills such as articulating a personal advising philosophy, building rapport, communicating respectfully and inclusively, guiding curriculum understanding, facilitating decision-making, and engaging in continuous self-assessment and professional growth (NACADA, 2017; Lochtie et al., 2018). Onboarding can integrate these skills through role-play scenarios, mentorship pairing, peer observation sessions, and reflective journaling on advising challenges. Together, these components provide a comprehensive foundation for developing advisors who are conceptually grounded, informationally competent, and relationally adept,

ensuring they are prepared to support student success and align with institutional values from day one.

Communication Challenges

Academic advising interactions are shaped by both the advisor's integration into the institution and the student's ability to navigate an unfamiliar academic environment. From the advisor's perspective, inadequate onboarding or incomplete socialization can lead to role ambiguity, inconsistent communication practices, and uncertainty about institutional policies (Van Maanen & Schein, 1979). For example, advisors who have not experienced sequential and fixed onboarding processes may be unclear on procedures for course substitutions or exception requests, leading to delayed responses to student inquiries. Without sufficient mentorship or peer integration, key serial and collective mechanisms of OST, new advisors may lack the confidence to address complex advising scenarios, resulting in guarded or overly cautious communication with students.

Students also face significant uncertainty when engaging with advisors, particularly in their first year. Uncertainty Reduction Theory (URT) suggests that individuals employ passive, active, and interactive strategies to make sense of new relationships and environments (Berger & Calabrese, 1975). In academic advising, students may engage in passive strategies by observing advisor demeanor during group sessions, active strategies by seeking information from peers, or interactive strategies by asking clarifying questions during appointments. However, these strategies can fail if advisors' communication styles are inconsistent or unclear, increasing student anxiety and reducing trust in the advising process.

Misalignments between advisor and student communication styles can further compound challenges. Advisors operating with incomplete role clarity may unintentionally provide

fragmented or contradictory information, undermining student confidence in academic planning. Conversely, students who hesitate to ask questions, often due to perceived power dynamics or fear of judgment, may leave advising sessions with unresolved concerns. Both OST and URT highlight that these issues can be addressed through structured socialization processes for advisors and intentional, relationship-building communication strategies with students. For example, implementing a formal, sequential onboarding program for advisors that includes mentorship (serial tactics), and cohort-based training (collective tactics) can improve message consistency and reduce advisor uncertainty. Similarly, advisors trained in URT-informed strategies, such as active listening and direct question prompts, can better address students' informational needs, reduce anxiety, and foster stronger advisor-student relationships.

Professional Development & Role Clarity

Professional development for advisors enhances their understanding of academic programs and institutional policies while improving their communication skills. In the field of communication, problem-solving and empathy, ultimately benefit both the advisors and the students they support. First, institutional integration is essential, as advisors must develop a clear understanding of university policies, advising frameworks, and the overall institutional culture. This foundational knowledge allows them to align their practices with the university's mission and values.

Role clarity is equally important; new advisors need to comprehend their specific responsibilities, which include collaborating with faculty, utilizing learning management system (LMS) tools such as Self-Service Degree Audit, Colleague, and Slate, as well as managing academic forms like exceptions and waivers. Ensuring that advisors are proficient in these areas promotes consistency and efficiency in advising practices. Communication competence is a critical

objective. Effective advising requires advisors to be able to communicate a variety of needs. Training advisors in URT-based strategies will enhance their ability to manage uncertainty in student interactions. Advisors will learn how to observe student cues, seek information proactively, and engage in meaningful conversations that build trust and provide clarity for students. Another goal is confidence building through practical application. Advisors will participate in hands-on practice scenarios to develop the confidence needed to handle diverse advising cases effectively. Lastly, continuous support will be established through mentoring programs and peer support networks. These ongoing support systems will ensure that advisor development does not end after initial onboarding but continues throughout their professional journey, fostering a collaborative and supportive advising community. Institutions that invest in high-quality advisor training demonstrate a commitment to student success, enhancing their reputation and distinguishing themselves in a competitive higher education market.

Uncertainty Reduction Theory & Onboarding

Uncertainty Reduction Theory (URT) is a theory of communication in developing relationships (Miller, 2005). The foundational premise of **Uncertainty Reduction Theory (URT)** states that individuals seek to reduce cognitive (*what to expect*) and behavioral (*how to act*) uncertainty through communicative and informational strategies. Berger and Calabrese (1975) suggests that people entering new social roles (such as academic advisors) feel anxious and seek clarity through communication strategies that reduce uncertainty. Within academic advising, high levels of ambiguity surrounding roles, campus culture, and advising norms can hinder advisor confidence and satisfaction. URT suggests that by proactively addressing these areas during onboarding, institutions can support advisors in developing a clear, confident, and proactive advising identity.

URT Strategy Breakdown

According to Uncertainty Reduction Theory, advisors can take on three main strategies to reduce uncertainty during initial interactions with students: passive, active, and interactive strategies (Berger & Calabrese, 1975). Passive strategies involve observation and indirect learning. For example, advisors may observe a student's nonverbal cues, such as hesitancy or frustration, review transcripts, identify academic flags, examine patterns in the learning management system (LMS), and listen without interruption to assess concerns and needs. Active strategies focus on seeking information from others. This may include consulting with faculty, mentors, and support staff; reviewing early alerts, midterm warnings, and overall academic trends; and using institutional tools such as Degree Audit, Colleague, and Slate to evaluate a student's progress. Interactive strategies involve direct engagement with the student. Advisors can ask open-ended and clarifying questions to build trust, rephrase and validate student concerns to reduce ambiguity, collaboratively set goals and develop action plans, and conduct regular check-ins to monitor progress (Gordon et al., 2018). When applied together, these strategies can help build trust, reduce relational ambiguity, and enhance the advisor's confidence in supporting student success.

Advisors can apply Uncertainty Reduction Theory (URT) by integrating passive, active, and interactive strategies to foster clarity and trust in student interactions. *Passive strategies* involve observing student behaviors and cues without direct engagement. For example, advisors can note nonverbal indicators such as hesitancy or frustration during appointments, carefully review transcripts and LMS activity patterns, and listen attentively without interruption to better understand student concerns. *Active strategies* require the advisor to seek information indirectly by consulting with faculty members, mentors, administrators, and support staff. They also involve reviewing early alerts, academic warnings, and analyzing student progress using platforms like

Degree Audit, Colleague, and Slate. *Interactive strategies* are centered on direct engagement with the student. Advisors should ask open-ended questions, rephrase and validate student concerns to reduce ambiguity, and collaboratively establish goals and action plans. Regular check-ins ensure continued progress monitoring and strengthen relational certainty between the advisor and student (Berger & Calabrese, 1975).

According to Bauer (2010), structured onboarding significantly eases role transition by offering clarity on tools, processes, and expectations, which fosters early independence among new advisors. Efficient onboarding focusing on systematic instruction must ensure that advisors quickly adapt to necessary tools and processes. Applying URT in advisor training could proactively address the unknown scenarios that new advisors may face. This approach minimizes initial confusion and increases their ability to work independently (Bauer, 2010). By integrating aspects of Uncertainty Reduction Theory (URT), which suggests that employees experience greater job satisfaction and productivity when they have clarity about job roles and organizational procedures, onboarding can foster an environment where they feel confident and well-equipped to meet role demands (Kramer, 2010).

URT & Onboarding Strategies

An effective onboarding process should prioritize training advisors on essential systems, and communication strategies, and should reduce workplace uncertainties. When both academic advisors and advisees are motivated to engage and invest in the relationship the desire for advising can lead to a more fulfilling advising relationship (Leach & Wang; 2015). By increasing knowledge and understanding of the role, student needs can be better addressed, providing accurate information and referrals when appropriate. This leads to more effective advising, increased student satisfaction, and improved student success rates.

URT-Informed Onboarding Strategies

According to Kramer (2010), there are three key strategies that are URT-Informed. One key strategy for reducing uncertainty during advisor onboarding is the use of *information-rich systems training*. This approach emphasizes hands-on experience with advising platforms, communication protocols, and essential workflows. By providing practical, applied training, new advisors can reduce task-related uncertainty and increase their self-efficacy. The second strategy involves *mentoring and interactive feedback*. Pairing new advisors with experienced or senior-level advisors creates opportunities for structured feedback and guided reflection, both of which reinforce Uncertainty Reduction Theory (URT) principles. This method not only models effective URT-based strategies but also supports cultural onboarding and reduces newcomer anxiety (Kramer, 2010). *Communication skill development* is an important component of URT-informed onboarding. Training in rapport building, constructive feedback delivery, and active listening equips advisors with the confidence to navigate student relationships effectively. These skills help decrease relational uncertainty while fostering an inclusive and supportive advising environment.

Instruction should focus on essential tools and systems including advising platforms and communication protocols (information-rich systems training), so advisors reduce task-related confusion early on and strengthen self-efficacy. Drawing from URT's passive, active, and interactive reduction strategies, pairing new hires with experienced advisors enables proactive communication and social integration (mentoring and interactive feedback). This mirrors Kramer's (2010) insights on structured support for newcomers to navigate organizational culture. By honing rapport-building and feedback techniques, advisors can more confidently manage interactions with both students and colleagues, easing relational uncertainty (communication skill development). Research specific to advisor–advisee dynamics emphasizes that when both participants are

motivated and engaged, sharing empathy, trust, and clarity, the quality of advising relationships noticeably improves. Studies by Leach and Wang (2015) emphasize the necessity of mutual commitment in fostering effective support and learning environments.

Organizational Socialization Theory (OST) & Onboarding

Onboarding directly impacts job efficiency, student retention, and organizational commitment. Research has shown that comprehensive onboarding processes, beyond basic orientation, lead to improved employee performance, engagement, and organizational commitment (Bauer et al. 2007; Bauer, 2010). According to Organizational Socialization Theory (OST), new advisors adapt to the organizational culture through a process of learning and integration (Van Maanen & Schein, 1979). OST suggests that both organizational level and individual factors work together to reduce uncertainty and promote integration into the organization. This project aims to use OST and URT as the theoretical frameworks when developing the proposed academic advising onboarding.

Organizational Socialization Theory (OST) Phases & Advisor Transition

Organizational socialization involves several key phases that guide newcomers from initial expectations to full integration within a workplace. The first stage, known as *anticipatory socialization*, takes place prior to entering the organization. During this phase, incoming advisors develop expectations about the organization and their prospective roles based on previous experiences, job interviews, and the organization's external reputation (Feldman, 1976). These preconceived notions shape how newcomers approach their new environment.

After joining the organization, advisors enter the *encounter phase*, where they confront the reality of their roles. This stage involves adjusting initial expectations (as newcomers engage directly with organizational practices), learning job responsibilities, and navigating workplace

dynamics (Van Maanen & Schein, 1979). Through observation and active participation, individuals begin to reconcile their assumptions with actual experiences. The final phase, referred to as the change and acquisition phase, is marked by the newcomer's mastery of job tasks and internalization of organizational values and norms. As they gain role clarity and self-assurance, they transition from outsiders to fully integrated insiders within the organization (Feldman, 1976; Van Maanen & Schein, 1979).The focus of OST is the transition from being an "outsider" to becoming an "insider" within an advising unit and the academic institution (Van Maanen & Schein, 1979). There are three phases that can be integrated in an academic advisor onboarding: Anticipatory Socialization, the Encounter Phase, and the Change and Acquisition Phase. *Anticipatory Socialization* occurs prior to entry into the organization. During this phase, newcomers form expectations based on prior experiences, interviews, and the organization's reputation.

The *Encounter Phase* begins when the new academic advisor officially joins the organization. This phase involves confronting the reality of the role, learning specific job requirements, and adjusting initial expectations accordingly. In the *Change and Acquisition Phase*, the new academic advisor masters job tasks and internalizes organizational norms. This phase marks the transition to being considered an insider, characterized by increased role clarity and confidence. The overall outcome of these phases facilitates cultural integration, institutional alignment, and the development of a professional identity within the organization.

OST Mechanisms & Academic Advising

Academic advisor onboarding requires structured socialization tactics that reduce role ambiguity while fostering competence and professional identity. Sequential and fixed tactics clarify responsibilities by providing step-by-step processes, such as guiding new advisors through

the use of institutional degree audits, course registration systems, and standardized advising scripts during initial training sessions (Van Maanen & Schein, 1979). For instance, a new advisor might be trained to use the Self-Service Degree Audit, a learning management system, to verify an incoming freshman's general education requirements, ensuring procedural consistency. Formal training workshops reinforce these tools and expectations by simulating real scenarios, such as advising a student on academic probation where advisors must navigate GPA calculations, probation contracts, and referrals to support services. To build competence and confidence, serial tactics involve pairing new advisors with experienced mentors who provide ongoing feedback. For example, a novice advisor might shadow a senior colleague during a graduation check appointment, learning how to interpret degree completion reports and manage any final semester advising complexities. Structured feedback sessions after these observations allow new advisors to refine their approach.

Facilitating peer integration through collective tactics, such as group or cohort-based onboarding programs, encourages new advisors to collaborate, share challenges, and develop a shared identity. A peer group or cohort might work together on advising a student to change their major, collectively strategizing the best academic plan. Finally, investiture tactics affirm advisors' existing strengths and reinforce institutional values through reflective practices. For instance, a new advisor with a background in student affairs might be encouraged to apply their knowledge of student engagement when advising first-generation students, with supervisors providing affirming feedback that aligns their personal strengths with the institution's advising culture (Bauer et al., 2007). Continuous role clarity is sustained through regular reflection meetings where advisors discuss their experiences, receive constructive feedback, and align their advising approach with institutional expectations.

Mechanisms of OST

Mechanisms of Organizational Socialization Theory (OST) operate through multiple structured tactics that support newly hired academic advisor adaptation and integration. These strategies are as follows: clarifying roles and processes, building competence and confidence, facilitating peer integration, and affirming identity and cultural fit (Van Maanen & Schein, 1979). *Role clarification and processes* often involve sequential and fixed tactics that reduce ambiguity about responsibilities, supplemented by formal training on advising tools, institutional processes, and performance expectations. *Building competence and confidence* is supported through serial tactics, such as mentorship and regular feedback, allowing new academic advisors to learn from experienced advisors through observation and guided practice. *Facilitating peer integration* is achieved through collective tactics, including cohort-based learning opportunities that foster community and a shared professional identity. *Affirming identity and cultural fit* relies on investiture tactics that acknowledge the new academic advisors' existing strengths. When these acknowledgements are reinforced through ongoing feedback and reflection, role clarity is also reinforced. For example, in an academic advisor onboarding program, new advisors might begin with a structured training schedule on the learning management system (LMS) or other student information systems (sequential and fixed), be paired with a senior advisor who provides weekly check-ins and observation opportunities (serial), participate in a new-hire advising cohort that engages in joint problem-solving scenarios (collective), and receive recognition for their prior advising or teaching experience during group discussions and feedback sessions (investiture). Together, these approaches promote cultural integration, institutional alignment, and the development of a confident and well-prepared professional identity.

The OST Dimensions & Academic Advisor Onboarding

According to Van Maanen and Schein (1979), OST is the process by which new advisors internalize the skills, norms, and cultural knowledge needed to perform effectively within the organization. Their six dimensions of socialization tactics: formal vs. informal, collective vs. individual, sequential vs. random, fixed vs. variable, serial vs. disjunctive, and investiture vs. divestiture. These dimensions shape how newcomers are integrated. For academic advisors, implementing structured, formal, mentor-supported onboarding aligns best with institutionalized socialization, which has been linked to stronger adjustment and commitment. Many people use these terms interchangeably, but they have different objectives. Onboarding primarily focuses on improving employee engagement, while orientation helps advisors familiarize themselves with their colleagues, understand organizational policies, and navigate the office space. Here's more about their differences.

The Six Dimensions of OST

Van Maanen and Schein (1979) identified six dimensions of Organizational Socialization Theory (OST) that describe how organizations structure the onboarding experience. The six dimensions are as follows: collective or individual, formal or informal, sequential or random, fixed or variable, serial or disjunctive, and investiture or divestiture. The *collective or individual dimension* reflects whether new academic advisors are socialized as part of a group or individually. A collective approach, such as cohort-based academic advisor training, allows new hires to learn together through shared workshops and peer discussion. An individual approach tailors onboarding to each advisor's assigned student population, prior experience, or functional focus. The *formal or informal dimension* distinguishes between structured programs and unstructured, on-the-job learning. For instance, a formal advising onboarding program might involve scheduled training on

degree audit systems and institutional policies, whereas an informal approach would allow advisors to learn these tools gradually through daily use.

The *sequential or random dimension* relates to whether onboarding follows a predetermined order. Sequential onboarding for advisors might involve step-by-step progression from shadowing appointments to conducting supervised sessions and eventually managing an independent caseload. Conversely, a random process would expose advisors to responsibilities in no set order, depending on departmental needs. The *fixed or variable dimension* considers whether there is a set timetable for progression. A fixed timeline might designate three weeks for system training before independent advising begins, whereas a variable approach would allow advisors to advance once they demonstrate readiness, regardless of time.

The *serial or disjunctive dimension* addresses whether new academic advisors have role models or mentors. In academic advising, serial tactics might involve pairing new advisors with seasoned advisors and staff who provide guidance and feedback during the first semester, while disjunctive tactics would require advisors to figure out the role independently, using only available resources. Lastly, the *investiture or divestiture dimension* focuses on whether the organization affirms or reshapes the new academic advisor's identity. An investiture approach in advising might highlight and leverage a new hire's prior teaching or student support experience, whereas divestiture would require them to adopt entirely new behaviors and values aligned with the institution's advising philosophy. Together, these dimensions offer a framework for designing academic advisors onboarding programs that balance structure, flexibility, mentorship, and identity development to support successful integration into the institution. Both newcomer adjustment and workforce outcomes are better when organizational socialization tactics involve collective and formalized experiences among newcomers, sequenced experiences according to an established

schedule, support and mentoring from existing workers, and recognition and support of newcomers' attitudes, skills, and abilities.

Conclusion

Integrating **Organizational Socialization Theory (OST)**, **Uncertainty Reduction Theory (URT)**, and **NACADA Core Competencies** in academic advisor onboarding creates a holistic framework for developing competent, confident, and student-centered advisors. OST addresses how new advisors learn institutional norms, values, and expectations, ensuring they understand their role within the university and the broader mission of academic advising (Van Maanen & Schein, 1979). Structured onboarding practices, such as formal training, mentorship, and clear communication of policies, support this socialization which encourages advisors feel connected, informed, and capable of navigating institutional systems. URT complements this by focusing on the interpersonal aspects of advising, guiding advisors to reduce uncertainty in student interactions through passive observation, active information-seeking, and interactive communication strategies (Berger & Calabrese, 1975). These strategies prepare advisors to establish trust, interpret student needs, and adopt an open, supportive environment.

NACADA Core Competencies further reinforce these theoretical foundations by providing a professional framework that guides advisors in conceptual, informational, and relational skill development (NACADA, 2017). Conceptual competencies enhance understanding of institutional and student development constructs, informational competencies ensure advisors can accurately interpret policies and academic data, and relational competencies support building meaningful, empathetic relationships with students. When combined, OST, URT, and NACADA competencies offer a comprehensive onboarding approach: OST ensures structural alignment and organizational integration, URT develops interpersonal efficacy, and NACADA competencies provide the

practical skills and professional standards that advisors need to succeed. This integrated approach benefits advisors, students, and the institution by cultivating advisors who are well-socialized, skilled in communication, and capable of guiding students effectively through their academic journeys, ultimately encouraging a more cohesive, student-centered learning environment.

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Onboarding Workshop Overview

This project aims to explore the critical role of communication within onboarding for academic advisors. The onboarding model will leverage in-person workshops and digital communication tools that streamline the dissemination of information for both new and seasoned advisors. Specifically, the workshop will create an opportunity for in person and hands-on interaction and the use of a learning management system (LMS), can provide access to training modules and discussion forums that will promote active engagement and communication among advisors. Digital platforms such as Microsoft Teams are additional technology resources that may help facilitate communication and provide a platform for regularly scheduled meetings, chats, and sharing of critical information. In addition to the communication methods used in the proposed onboarding project, the developed training materials will support advisor efficiency, organizational integration, and long-term well-being.

Effective academic advisor onboarding is critical for fostering role clarity, confidence, and long-term professional success. This workshop integrates Uncertainty Reduction Theory (URT) and Organizational Socialization Theory (OST) as foundational frameworks to enhance the onboarding experience for new advisors. URT emphasizes how individuals actively seek information to reduce uncertainties in new interactions and environments, which is essential as advisors navigate unfamiliar institutional structures and student interactions (Berger & Calabrese, 1975). OST complements this by focusing on how individuals learn, internalize, and perform their organizational roles, adjusting expectations through structured socialization processes (Katz & Kahn, 1978).

By blending URT's emphasis on information-seeking behaviors and OST's structured phases of role adaptation, this workshop provides new advisors with strategies to manage ambiguity, build professional networks, and gain clarity on institutional expectations. The training

includes communication theory exploration, NACADA resources, scenario-based learning, peer mentoring, and active reflection to align advisors' anticipatory expectations with organizational realities, ultimately facilitating a smoother transition into their advising roles.

Rationale

An efficient and layered onboarding strategy will not only enhance individual job performance but also contribute to organizational stability by reducing turnover rates and promoting a positive work culture. This project distinguishes between orientation, which serves as an introductory and compliance step, and onboarding, which encompasses a comprehensive, identity-focused integration process. For example, communication within orientation is often reduced to 1-2 days or a single session. The approach is typically one-way information (i.e. presentations or handbooks). Whereas onboarding is a comprehensive communication method that fosters engagement, extends over several weeks or months, and is more interactive (i.e., role-play scenarios, job-specific training or performance feedback). These communication strategies may lead to advisors feeling more prepared and supported (Woodrow & Guest, 2019).

Objective

The objective of this workshop is to yield professional growth, collaboration, and continuous learning within the field of academic advising. This includes understanding effective communication, advising techniques and best practices. Additionally, onboarding will facilitate strategies for building rapport with students, address student challenges, empower students to set independent goals and make informed decisions. Both new and experienced Academic Advisors seeking to enhance their knowledge, skills, and effectiveness in their roles can utilize this project as a valuable professional development resource. Effective academic advising significantly influences student success, retention, and graduation rates.

Conclusion

The integration of Uncertainty Reduction Theory (URT), Organizational Socialization Theory (OST), and the NACADA core competencies provide a comprehensive framework for academic advisor onboarding that addresses both interpersonal and organizational learning needs. By applying URT, onboarding programs can intentionally reduce newcomer uncertainty through proactive information-seeking, structured mentoring, and open communication, promoting confidence in early advisor-student interactions (Berger & Calabrese, 1975). OST complements this by emphasizing phased socialization, organizational culture acclimation, and role clarity, ensuring that new advisors adapt to institutional norms while building job competence over time (Van Maanen & Schein, 1979). When aligned with NACADA's conceptual, informational, and relational core competencies, onboarding becomes both strategically structured and developmentally supportive, arming advisors with the knowledge, skills, and values necessary for effective practice (NACADA, 2017). Together, this integrated approach not only enhances advisor readiness and retention but also strengthens student success outcomes by ensuring advisors are well-prepared to navigate complex institutional processes while building authentic, trust-based relationships with students.

The Workshop Format

(Facilitated by an experienced Academic Advisor or an Academic Advising Unit Head)

Workshop Objective: The objective of this workshop is to enhance academic advisors' onboarding experience by applying *Organizational Socialization Theory (OST)* and *Uncertainty Reduction Theory (URT)* to reduce role ambiguity and promote effective role adaptation. OST outlines the structured phases through which newcomers learn and internalize organizational values, progressing from anticipatory socialization to full role acquisition (Feldman, 1976; Van Maanen & Schein, 1979). At the same time, URT highlights the proactive information-seeking behaviors individuals use to mitigate uncertainty in unfamiliar environments (Berger & Calabrese, 1975). By integrating these theories, the workshop aims to provide advisors with tools to clarify role expectations, develop strategies for effective interpersonal communication, and build confidence in navigating institutional processes.

After the workshop is complete, participants will be able to:

- Identify and apply strategies to reduce uncertainty in new advising interactions.
- Describe the phases of organizational socialization and their impact on role clarity.
- Utilize proactive information-seeking techniques to foster professional relationships within the institution.
- Align personal expectations with institutional values and role responsibilities.
- Demonstrate increased confidence in navigating advising systems, policies, and student engagement.

Using Bloom's Taxonomy, URT & OST Frameworks

Advisors move from first year expectations to mastery of the foundational aspects of advising on a continuum through a learning taxonomy: a hierarchy of learning behaviors built on the simplest concepts and practice and extending through degrees of difficulty toward the most complex actions (Clark, 2015). P. 11

Remember	Define key concepts of Uncertainty Reduction Theory (URT) and Organizational Socialization Theory (OST) as they relate to advisor onboarding.
	Recall the phases of organizational socialization: anticipatory socialization, encounter, and change & acquisition (Feldman, 1976).
Understand	Explain how proactive information-seeking behaviors reduce uncertainty during initial advisor-student interactions (Berger & Calabrese, 1975).
	Describe how role clarity and organizational culture are developed through structured onboarding (Van Maanen & Schein, 1979).
Apply	Demonstrate strategies for reducing role ambiguity by actively seeking information from institutional resources (e.g., colleagues, manuals, systems).
	Apply structured socialization practices to align personal advising styles with institutional expectations.
Analyze	Identify potential gaps between personal anticipatory expectations and organizational realities during the onboarding process.
	Examine real-world advising scenarios to determine which URT strategies (passive, active, interactive) are most effective in reducing uncertainty.
Evaluate	Assess their own onboarding experience for areas where role clarity could be enhanced using OST frameworks.
	Critique advising approaches in peer discussions to determine their effectiveness in fostering advisor-student rapport and reducing uncertainties.
Create	Develop a personalized onboarding action plan that outlines specific strategies for integrating into the advising role using URT information-seeking behaviors and OST phase progression.
	Design collaborative strategies for ongoing role development and professional socialization within their advising team.

WORKSHOP POWERPOINT PRESENTATION DESCRIPTION

WELCOME

Welcome participants and introduce the workshop title.

- Briefly mention that today's session will explore how Uncertainty Reduction Theory (URT) and Organizational Socialization Theory (OST) work together to create an effective onboarding process for academic advisors.

WORKSHOP OBJECTIVES

- Understand URT and OST principles.
- Define academic advising using NACADA standards.
- Identify NACADA Core Competencies and advising approaches.
- Apply OST's phased approach to advisor role development.
- Develop a personalized onboarding action plan.

WHY EFFECTIVE ONBOARDING MATTERS

- Explain how poor onboarding leads to role ambiguity, advisor burnout, and inconsistent student support.
- Highlight that effective onboarding reduces anxiety and fosters advisor confidence (Katz & Kahn, 1978).

DEFINING ACADEMIC ADVISING (NACADA)

- Present NACADA's definition: Academic advising is a series of intentional interactions with a curriculum, a pedagogy, and a set of student learning outcomes (NACADA, 2006).
- Emphasize the advisor's role in guiding students through academic, career, and personal development.

NACADA CORE COMPETENCIES

Outline the three core competency areas:

- Conceptual: Theoretical framework of advising.
- Informational: Knowledge of institutional policies, procedures, and resources.
- Relational: Interpersonal skills to build advising relationships.

ADVISING STYLES AND APPROACHES (NACADA)

Discuss key advising styles:

- Prescriptive Advising: Advisor-centered, directive.
- Developmental Advising: Student-centered, fostering autonomy.
- Appreciative Advising: Strengths-based, positive reinforcement.

Explain when to apply each style depending on student needs.

INTRODUCTION TO UNCERTAINTY REDUCTION THEORY (URT)

- Define URT as a communication theory that explains how individuals seek information to reduce uncertainty in new situations (Berger & Calabrese, 1975).
- Emphasize that advisors experience high uncertainty during initial entry and need strategies to manage it.

URT INFORMATION-SEEKING STRATEGIES

Break down three methods:

- Passive (observing processes and behaviors)
- Active (asking third parties for information)
- Interactive (direct engagement and questions)

Provide examples: observing advising appointments, consulting experienced advisors, asking direct questions in meetings.

INTRODUCTION TO ORGANIZATION SOCIALIZATION THEORY (OST)

- Define OST as the process through which newcomers learn the values, norms, and expected behaviors of an organization (Feldman, 1976).
- Explain how structured onboarding aligns new advisors with institutional culture.

OST PHASES OF SOCIALIZATION

- Anticipatory Socialization: Forming expectations before entry.
- Encounter Phase: Reality shock and adjustment upon starting.
- Change & Acquisition Phase: Mastering tasks and internalizing norms (Van Maanen & Schein, 1979).

URT AND OST: A COLLABORATIVE FRAMEWORK

- Explain that URT provides tactics (information-seeking) while OST provides structure (phases of adaptation).
- Illustrate with an example: In the Encounter Phase, advisors use active URT strategies to clarify expectations.

PRACTICAL INFORMATION-SEEKING FOR ADVISORS

List practical URT behaviors:

- Attend training sessions (active)
- Shadow senior advisors (passive/interactive)
- Utilize LMS tools (active problem-solving)

Explain how these reduce task-specific uncertainties.

ROLE CLARITY & EXPECTATIONS

- Discuss common areas where role ambiguity occurs (e.g., policies, advising caseloads).
- Stress the importance of aligning personal advising approaches with institutional expectations using OST as a guide.

ADVISING SCENARIO – INCOMING FRESHMAN

- Scenario: An incoming freshman is overwhelmed with general education requirements and unsure about selecting a major.
- Discuss using Appreciative Advising to build rapport and highlight student strengths.
- Apply active URT strategies to gather information about the student's interests.
- Relate this scenario to the Encounter Phase of OST.

ADVISING SCENARIO – GRADUATING SENIOR

- Scenario: A senior student needs assistance with graduation application and post-graduation planning.
- Emphasize Developmental Advising to encourage autonomy in decision-making.
- Use interactive URT strategies to clarify remaining degree requirements.
- Align this scenario with the Change & Acquisition Phase.

ADVISING SCENARIO – CHANGE OF MAJOR

- Scenario: A sophomore is contemplating changing majors but is uncertain about the process and implications.
- Apply a combination of Prescriptive Advising (explaining policies) and Developmental Advising (encouraging self-assessment).
- Use active URT strategies to gather information from department chairs.
- Relate this scenario to the Encounter Phase.

ADVISING SCENARIO – STUDENT ON ACADEMIC PROBATION

- Scenario: A student has been placed on academic probation and is anxious about the next steps.
- Utilize Appreciative Advising to provide positive reinforcement and build confidence.
- Use interactive URT strategies to develop a success plan with referrals to support resources.
- Connect this to the Change & Acquisition Phase as the student rebuilds academic standing.

BUILDING PROFESSIONAL RELATIONSHIPS

- Emphasize the role of relationship-building in reducing uncertainty and fostering integration.
- Example: Engaging with faculty and deans to clarify policies is an active URT strategy that accelerates the Change & Acquisition Phase.

PERSONALIZED ONBOARDING ACTION PLAN

Guide participants through drafting an action plan:

- Identify uncertainties they currently face.
- Determine URT strategies to address them.
- Map these actions into OST phases for structured progression.

WORKSHOP SUMMARY & KEY TAKEAWAYS

Recap key points:

- URT helps advisors actively reduce uncertainty.
- OST offers a phased roadmap for professional integration.
- NACADA Core Competencies provide a foundation for advising effectiveness.
- Successful onboarding blends theory with practical, scenario-based learning.

NEXT STEPS & RESOURCES

Provide follow-up resources:

- Peer mentoring programs.
- Advising resource manuals.
- LMS (Self-Service Degree Audit, Colleague, Slate) tutorials.
- Offer contact info for further support.